

damage to a chronicle if left unchecked for even a short period of time. Such “trolling” players are best dismissed from a game, and quickly, unless they sincerely apologize and change their ways immediately. Storytellers, do not feel bad about removing such players from your groups, and even retroactively undoing any damaging actions their characters took that sent the story off course or upset the other players; the rest of the group will thank you for standing up for them and protecting their enjoyment of the game.

let Wins and losses Stand

As a Storyteller, it can be easy to fall into the mindset of wanting to “defeat” the players, but this can lead to the temptation to rob players of victories they’ve rightfully earned, and there are few faster ways to turn a game sour than punishing the players for being clever (or lucky).

If the players come up with a clever scheme that potentially vanquishes a villain more easily than the Storyteller had expected, or get a lucky roll that blows the lid off a mystery, or figure out how to bypass an obstacle that was supposed to be a major issue, then *let them have their victory*. They earned it, and so they should be able to enjoy it. A Storyteller can always devise more obstacles and antagonists, after all, so there’s no point in negating the actions of the players just to preserve existing ones for an arbitrary reason.

By the same token, if the players fail, don’t take away the consequences of that failure or all sense of risk will quickly evaporate. This doesn’t mean rubbing the players’ noses in it by any means — gloating is a poor habit in Storytellers and players alike — but just resisting the temptation to soften punishments, rewind events, or otherwise undo the consequences of players failing (or simply making hard decisions). If players are having a hard time with consequences, it’s generally better to take a time out and talk about it out of character than to respond by softening the response in the fiction.

This is not to say that sometimes victories may turn out to be mixed blessings, for example, or that losses might not be as bad as they first appear, but all such moments should always be firmly supported by the events of the story and not simply thrown in as last-minute alterations.

logistics, logistics, logistics

Although it’s easy to overlook matters of snacks, hosting, and scheduling as compared to issues like handling problem players or mastering descriptions, such nuts and bolts are just as vital to the success of an ongoing chronicle, if not more so. Hosting a game night can be a demanding task, especially with a large group, not to mention feeding the whole crew as they gather around the table. With that in mind, it’s a good idea to spread out hosting duties if possible, and regardless always make sure the host gets plenty of help with cleaning up before and after game. The same goes for considering players who have to travel to attend; rotating carpool duties, or kicking in for gas and travel costs, is a good way to keep everyone happy.

